

Achieving balance

When a person is absorbed in playing a video game, it can be very easy for hours to roll by. However, prolonged periods of screen time are unhealthy, for the body and mind, and other aspects of life—such as seeing friends, doing homework, exercising, or sleeping—can end up being neglected. No matter what the game type, gaming is a sedentary, often solitary, pastime. To stay healthy, it's a good idea to fit in time for physical exercise, and to play video games as a family activity to make it sociable.



△ Screen time

Prolonged amounts of screen time are linked to obesity.

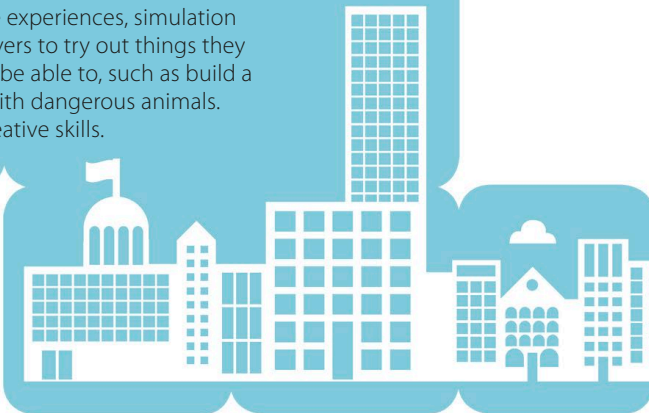
PARENT TIPS

Video game ratings

Most games carry ratings, which recommend an age group based on their contents. Different countries use different regulatory boards, but the most widely used systems are those by the Entertainment Software Rating Board (ESRB) in the U.S., and Pan-European Game Information (PEGI). It's worth considering these ratings if your teen asks to play a game that is too old for them. If necessary, many game consoles have settings that can be used to limit what games are accessible.

Simulation games

Based on real-life experiences, simulation games allow players to try out things they wouldn't usually be able to, such as build a city or interact with dangerous animals. They develop creative skills.



Strategy games

Requiring players to plan their moves and tactics skillfully to achieve their goals, strategy games improve logical thinking to overcome problems, and often depend on a player's ability to manage resources better than their opponents.

Playing online

Many games have an online option, which allows users to play and communicate with others around the world. This can be a fun way for teens to socialize with friends, but it can also open up contact with strangers. Basic security awareness—such as using an avatar to play and not using or giving out personal details, including name, address, and pictures—will keep online gaming safe. If other players become abusive or inappropriate, it's possible to report and block them.

GOOD TO KNOW

Microtransactions

Microtransactions, or in-app purchases, are small payments for elements within a game, such as extra levels or abilities. They feature in many games, particularly those designed for smartphones. These small payments can easily turn into large credit-card bills, so it is essential to keep tabs on any in-app purchases. It is also possible to disable microtransactions from the settings menu of most smartphones.